

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Undergraduate Examinations 2012

CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: **THREE** hours

Candidates are permitted to bring into the examination room paper dictionaries (with the title in English).

Candidates must answer **THREE** questions in total: **ONE** from **SECTION A**, **ONE** from **SECTION B**, and **ONE** from either **SECTION A** or **SECTION B**.

The paper consists of **seventeen** questions in total: nine in Section A and eight in Section B.

All questions are of equal weight.

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator.
Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.
Do not open the question paper until told to do so.
All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided.
All rough work must be written in the answer book(s) provided. A line should be drawn through any rough work to indicate to the examiner that it is not part of the work to be marked.
At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

SECTION A

Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B, and one from either Section A or Section B.

1. Outline the theoretical basis of the claim that sociology is “scientific” and assess the implications of such an approach.
2. Interpretivists (and neo-Kantians) often state that sociology has a different ontological basis to that of natural science. Explain what they mean by this and assess the implications of such a claim.
3. Define the premises of phenomenological sociology, and discuss the main strengths and weaknesses of this approach.
4. Critical realism combines in one approach claims about (i) knowability of the world through rational scientific enquiry and (ii) the inescapable fallibility of the knowledge acquired through this process. Explain the meaning of these two assumptions and discuss their compatibility.
5. ‘Normal science’ is a barrier to social progress. Do you agree?
6. In order to influence social change, actors must be conscious. Discuss with reference to Latour.
7. ‘Feminist epistemology should strive for more objectivity, not less.’ Explain and critically assess this statement.
8. Did ‘the West’ construct ‘the Rest’?
9. Some post-structuralists claim that no basis for meaning can be found in language or the world. Outline and assess the arguments they make to develop such a position and the implications for social theory.

END OF SECTION A

SECTION B

Candidates must answer THREE questions in total: one from Section A, one from Section B, and one from either Section A or Section B.

10. Is power repressive or productive?
11. 'Power corrupts; absolute power corrupts absolutely.' Assess this statement with reference to Foucault's concept of biopower. In your response, address two things. First, what is biopower? Second, does biopower corrupt social life, or improve it?
12. Capital is not simply an economic asset. Do you agree?
13. Outline and assess Barthes' account of the relation between myths and ideology.
14. 'Modernity is a specific way of experiencing time and space.' Explain and critically discuss this proposition.
15. The postmodernist approach has often been equated with extreme relativism. Explain and critically discuss this claim.
16. Some Marxist writers argue that the current ecological crisis is caused by globalising capitalism. Are they right about this? Answer with reference to at least one named writer.
17. 'In order to be relevant, contemporary feminism must recognize the diversity of women's experience.' Discuss.

END OF SECTION B

END OF PAPER SC301-6-FY